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Human trafficking—it happens here | Guest Commentary

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The movie "Sound of Freedom," which looks at child sex trafficking, is one of the most popular movies right now. Its mantra: "God's children are not for sale."

Unfortunately, you wouldn't know that by watching our Assembly members in Sacramento.

The Assembly Public Safety Committee recently voted 2-6 on party lines to shoot down Senate Bill 14, which would increase the penalties for child sex trafficking.

After public uproar, Assembly Republicans attempted to bring the bill, which had the support of Gov. Gavin Newsom, to the floor for a vote. But Democrats refused and referred it back to the Assembly Public Safety Committee.

When Ventura County's legislators had a chance to take a stand against a $32-billion industry, they each refused to take the action needed to protect our kids, proving again how out of touch our Democratic legislators truly are.

Assemblymembers Jacqui Irwin (D-Thousand Oaks) and Jesse Gabriel (D-Woodland Hills) couldn't even be bothered to do the job we pay them to do, as neither voted on the motion to bring the bill to the Assembly floor for a vote. Irwin then had the audacity to claim on social media that she "voted . . . to require the Assembly Public Safety (Committee) to rehear the bill," even though she didn't bother actually casting a vote.

Thankfully, when the bill was reheard in the Assembly Public Safety Committee, enough Democrats found a conscience and voted with the committee's Republicans to advance it. Now, it moves to the Assembly Appropriations Committee.

How will Ventura County's legislators vote when the bill comes back to the full Assembly? Will they support children or pedophiles? It's hard to know for sure. At the very least, Irwin is good at sticking her finger in the air to see which way the wind is blowing.

Regardless of her claims, concerned citizens might want to call the offices of their Assembly members and urge them to support this important bill.

Next year, the voters in Ventura County will again have a chance to show how they feel about protecting our children. Hopefully, voters send the message that Ventura County will not support elected officials who look like they support child sex traffickers over our children.

It's time to restore some sanity to Sacramento by replacing these ineffective representatives with candidates who will work to keep our children safe from predators who deal deadly drugs and traffic children for sex.

John Andersen is a former trustee of Conejo Valley Unified School District and serves as chair of the Ventura County Republican Party.

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